

Arthur's Seat - Kids

UK Family Tour

Sleeping Volcanoes Under a Whole City

Here is something wild about the city you are standing in. Almost the whole of Edinburgh is built on top of old volcanoes. Not one volcano, but a bunch of them. That giant rock the castle sits on? Volcano. The big green hill you are going to climb today? Volcano. Bumps and ridges all over the city? Volcanoes, or the leftover bits of them.

Now, do not worry. These volcanoes are extinct, which means dead, finished, done erupting forever. They last blew their tops around three hundred and forty million years ago. That is so long ago that there were no dinosaurs yet, none at all. Back then Scotland was not even here. It sat down near the equator where it is hot, and this spot was a steamy swamp beside the sea. Imagine that instead of chilly Edinburgh.

So where did the volcanoes go? Two things happened. First, over millions of years, the soft outside of each volcano wore away in the wind and rain, leaving only the super hard rock that had cooled deep inside. Then, much later, gigantic sheets of ice called glaciers came grinding over the whole country and scraped everything smooth, like a giant hand rubbing sandpaper across the land. The hills you see today are the parts that were tough enough to survive all of that.

And now the best bit. People long ago noticed that a big steep rock is a brilliant place to build a castle, because enemies cannot climb up it. So that is exactly what they did. The city grew up around its volcanoes. And today you get to climb one of them yourself. Ready?

The Giant Ice That Shaped the Hills

Let us talk about the ice, because it did something amazing to this city. A long, long time ago, way after the volcanoes went quiet, the whole country got buried under ice. Not a little bit of ice, like a frozen puddle. We are talking sheets of ice taller than the tallest buildings, so heavy and so slow they crawled across the land like frozen rivers. This happened again and again over about two million years.

Now imagine that ice comes sliding along and bumps into one of those super hard volcano rocks, like the one under Edinburgh Castle. The ice cannot smash through it. The rock is far too tough. So the ice splits and goes around it, scraping away all the soft ground on the sides. But right behind the rock, in its shadow, the ground is protected. The ice cannot get at it properly. So it leaves a long, gentle slope trailing away behind the tough rock.

Geologists have a funny name for this shape. They call it a crag and tail. The crag is the big tough rock that won the fight with the ice, and it usually has a steep cliff on one side. The tail is the long ramp sloping down behind it, where the ground hid in the shelter.

Now for the cool part. Once you know that shape, you can spot it. Look at Edinburgh Castle. It sits way up on the steep crag, with cliffs dropping away below it. And that famous old street called the Royal Mile? It runs straight down the tail behind the castle. The whole old town is sitting in a glacier's shadow.

And it happened more than once. If you ever visit a town called Stirling, about an hour away, you will see the exact same thing. A castle high on a tough rock, and an old town sliding down the slope behind it. Same rock, same ice trick, two different castles. Once you have seen a crag and tail, you cannot stop seeing them.

The Man Who Found Out the Earth Is Super Old

Now for a true story about a big idea, and it started right here on rocks like these. A really long time ago, most grown-ups thought the Earth was only about six thousand years old. That sounds like a lot, but it is not, not really. Six thousand years is younger than some trees that are alive today.

Then a man from Edinburgh named James Hutton went walking around hills exactly like this one, back in the seventeen hundreds. He was a farmer who loved rocks, and he stared at them really, really carefully. And he noticed something that did not add up. He could see that some rock had once been runny and hot, squeezed up from deep underground. And he could see that other rock was made of tiny grains, squished mud from the bottom of an ancient sea, packed down hard over ages and ages. He realized all of this had taken a mind-bending amount of time. Not thousands of years. Millions and millions and millions of years.

This idea got a name. People call it deep time. It just means the Earth is so unbelievably, ridiculously old that your whole life, even the lives of your great great grandparents all added together, is less than a single blink. Hutton was one of the very first people to figure this out, by reading it in rocks like the ones under your feet. That is why some people call him the father of geology, which is the science of rocks and the Earth. Pretty good for a fellow who liked walking up hills.

And now the wow. The hill you are climbing today, Arthur's Seat, is a real wild mountain. It has long grass, rocky cliffs, and big birds circling overhead, and you might spot rabbits. But look around, because it is sitting right in the middle of a busy capital city, next door to a palace where a king or queen actually stays. Almost no other capital in the whole world has a wild mountain plonked in the middle of it. And you get to climb it, for free, today. Not many kids can say they climbed a volcano before lunch.

You Are Climbing a Volcano

Today you're climbing an actual volcano. Arthur's Seat erupted about three hundred and fifty million years ago, long before dinosaurs, when Scotland sat near the equator and this whole area was a steamy tropical swamp beside a shallow sea. The volcano is thoroughly extinct, the geologists promise, and ice-age glaciers have since scraped it into the lion-shaped hill you see. Lots of people think it looks like a sleeping lion: the summit is the lion's head, and the long ridge is its body. Nobody knows for sure where the name comes from. The romantic story says it's King Arthur's seat, and some legends even claim Arthur and his knights sleep in a cave under the hill, waiting for Scotland's hour of greatest need. As you walk the path under Salisbury Crags, the big cliff of orange rock, you're in a genuinely famous place for science. A man named James Hutton studied these exact rocks in the seventeen eighties and realized the Earth must be unimaginably older than anyone believed. People used to think Earth was six thousand years old. Hutton looked at these crags and proved it took millions upon millions of years. He basically discovered deep time, right here. Keep an eye out for the ruined chapel on the smaller hill, and for rabbits, which own this park.

Related listening: Castle Rock and Arthur's Seat are siblings, vents of the same ancient volcano field. Listen back — "The Most Attacked Castle in Britain" (Edinburgh Castle, Day 9). Related listening: The Old Town rides the volcano's tail; the climb takes you up the volcano itself. Listen back — "A City Built on a Volcano's Tail" (Royal Mile & Old Town, Day 9).

The People Who Lived on the Volcano

Long before anyone climbed this hill for fun, people lived up here. Right on the summit you're heading for, more than two thousand years ago, there was a fort. Iron Age families built it as a stronghold, a safe high place they could defend. Look for two low stony banks running along the eastern side of the hill. Those humps are the worn-down remains of the fort's ramparts, the walls that once guarded the gap between the top and the smaller peak beside it. And here's a surprise: this hill isn't the only fort in the park. There were four altogether, on different crags around you, so the whole place was once dotted with hilltop homes.

The people who lived here are called the Votadini, and we barely know them, but we do have one amazing thing: a very old poem, written down around the year six hundred, that remembers their warriors. Imagine that. The people who watched the sunrise from this exact spot are so old that they live on only in a song.

Now look at the lower slopes on the eastern side, the ones facing the little village of Duddingston. When the sun is low and the light goes slanty, you can see long flat steps cut into the grass, like giant stairs. Those are cultivation terraces. Ancient farmers carved flat shelves into the steep hillside so they could plough and grow food without everything rolling downhill. They're some of the best-preserved anywhere near Edinburgh, and most people walk right past without noticing them.

There's one more human ruin to spot, and it's a good one. On a rocky shoulder above a little loch stands the broken shell of St Anthony's Chapel, a stone building from the Middle Ages. Nobody is completely sure why it was built here, or exactly when, which is wonderfully mysterious for a whole chapel. Perhaps monks or a lone holy man once lived beside it, saying prayers with that huge view spread out below, watching ships come up the river. Today only one tall corner still stands, like a stone finger pointing at the sky.

So as you climb, remember you're not the first. Think of the fort-builders hauling stones to the top, the farmers digging their terraces, the hermit in his little chapel. For thousands of years, people have chosen

this old volcano as a place to live, to farm, to pray, and to keep watch. You're just the newest visitors in a very, very long line, and the hill has quietly kept all their marks for you to find.

The Best View in the City

When you finally reach the top, stop, catch your breath, and turn slowly all the way around. You're standing two hundred and fifty-one metres up, on the highest point for miles, and on a clear day this is one of the best views in Scotland. Let's play a game of I-spy from the roof of Edinburgh.

Look west first, back the way most people come. The whole Old Town spills down a long ridge, with Edinburgh Castle perched on its own crag at the far end. That castle rock hides a secret. It's a volcano too, a cousin of the one you're standing on, born from the same fiery time. You're looking from one dead volcano across to another.

Now turn to the north. That wide sheet of silvery water is the Firth of Forth, where the river meets the sea. Beyond it is a whole other region called Fife. On a clear day you can spot the Forth bridges away to the west, about twelve miles off. One of them is a giant red railway bridge that's more than a hundred and thirty years old, so long that trains have been rumbling across it since your great-great-grandparents were children.

Swing round to the east now, out toward the open sea, and look for a pale lump of rock sitting in the water. That's the Bass Rock, and believe it or not, it's yet another ancient volcano. It looks white from here, but that colour isn't snow or paint. It's birds. Tens of thousands of seabirds called gannets nest on it every summer, so many that they turn the whole rock white. Near it you might see a pointed hill called North Berwick Law, another volcano again. This whole coast is a graveyard of them.

Look south and you'll find a long green wall of hills on the horizon. Those are the Pentlands. And on a truly perfect, sparkling day, if you're really lucky, you can see far to the north-west all the way to the edge of the Highlands, the wild mountains that fill the top half of Scotland.

Right below your feet is the city itself, laid out like a model railway. See if you can find the palace with its towers, which is where the King stays when he's in Scotland, and the modern parliament building beside it. Trace the streets, spot the church spires, watch the tiny buses.

Not many cities let you climb a wild, rocky mountain and look down on the whole thing at once. Take a photo in your head. This is a view people have been climbing up to enjoy for thousands of years, and now it's yours.

Dragons, Knights, and a Road Built by Hand

Every good hill needs good stories, and this one has piles of them. Start with the name itself, Arthur's Seat. Nobody actually knows where it comes from, which leaves plenty of room for legends, and people have happily filled that room for hundreds of years.

The most famous story says the hill is named for King Arthur, the legendary king with the round table and the sword in the stone. Some versions go further and whisper that Arthur and his knights aren't dead at all, but sleeping in a hidden cave deep inside the hill, in their armour, waiting. The tale says that one day, when Scotland needs them most, a horn will sound and they'll wake and ride out. Now, is any of that true? Almost certainly not. But it's a wonderful thing to think about while you stand on top of their supposed roof.

Here's an even better one. The story goes that this whole hill is a dragon. A great dragon once feasted on the fields around Edinburgh until it was so enormously stuffed and sleepy that it curled up right here to rest, and it fell into such a deep sleep that grass grew over it, and it slowly turned to stone. So when you

climb the long ridge, some people say you're clambering up the back of a sleeping dragon. Look at the shape of the hill and see if you agree. Again, it's a story, not a fact, but it's a brilliant one.

There's a real tradition here too, and this one people genuinely still do. On the first morning of May, before the sun is properly up, folk climb the hill and wash their faces in the cold morning dew, because there's an old belief it makes you beautiful and lucky for the year. So on one dawn each spring, this hilltop fills with laughing, shivering people patting wet grass on their cheeks.

Now look down at the bottom of the big orange cliffs for a path called the Radical Road. Back in 1820, times were hard and many weavers, people whose job was making cloth, had no work and no money. So they were set to work building this very path along the foot of the crags, an idea suggested by the famous writer Walter Scott. They laid every stone by hand. These days parts of it are closed off, because chunks of rock sometimes tumble down from above.

That's a good reminder. This hill is real and a bit wild. The dark rock gets very slippery when it's wet, so if today is rainy, take the gentler path under Salisbury Crags rather than scrambling to the very top. Dragons or no dragons, we want you coming home in one piece.

A Beach Smell and Invisible Singers

Here's a trick. Stop walking for a second, close your eyes, and just smell the hill. If it's a sunny day and you're near those big bushes covered in bright yellow flowers, take a good deep sniff. Coconut. Honestly, coconut, like sun cream or a tropical beach, right here on a cold Scottish hill. Those spiky bushes are called gorse, and their little yellow flowers really do smell of coconut when the sun warms them up. It's one of the best secrets on Arthur's Seat, and almost nobody tells you about it. Careful though, don't grab the gorse, because underneath the coconut smell it's covered in sharp green spikes. Smell, don't touch.

Now keep your eyes shut and listen. On a fine morning you might hear a bird singing and singing and singing, a tumbling silvery song that never seems to stop, but when you open your eyes and look, there's nothing there. Where is it? Look straight up, higher than you think. That's a skylark, and it does something amazing. It flies almost straight up into the sky, so high it turns into a tiny dot, and it sings the whole time it's climbing, then it parachutes back down still singing. People have loved that invisible song for hundreds of years. See if your family can be the first to spot the singer.

There's more life here than you'd guess on a bare-looking hill. The rabbits, of course, are everywhere, and this whole park really does belong to them. Watch for the white flash of a bobbing tail as one bolts for its burrow. But look up sometimes too, because the cliffs are home to one of the fastest animals on the whole planet, a bird called a peregrine falcon. When a peregrine folds its wings and dives on its dinner, it goes faster than a racing car, faster than any other creature alive. Somewhere on these crags, that little grey speck could be the fastest thing in the world just sitting there having a rest.

In summer there are butterflies bobbing over the grass, tough little birds hiding in the gorse, and wildflowers you'd never see in a tidy garden. Listen for a big black bird up on the crags making a deep, croaky call, more of a bark than a tweet. That's a raven, the biggest of all the crow family, and it loves rocky, wild places exactly like this. And feel the wind, because up here it can go from a gentle push to a proper shove, whistling round the rocks, so hold onto your hat and your little ones near the edges. So this hill is no dead lump of old volcano. It's alive, top to bottom. Use all your senses as you climb. Smell the coconut, hunt for the invisible singer, watch for the world's fastest bird. A good explorer doesn't just look. A good explorer sniffs and listens too.

Three Lochs and the Swans

This hill has three little lakes hiding around it, and in Scotland a lake is called a loch. Each one is different, and two of them have a surprising secret: they aren't really wild at all. People made them on purpose.

The first one you might pass is called Saint Margaret's Loch, down near that ruined old chapel. It's the swan loch. Look for big white swans gliding about like they own the place, with ducks and hungry geese paddling around them. Swans are much bigger up close than you expect, and they can be a bit bossy, so it's fine to watch them but don't get too near, because a grumpy swan is not something you want to argue with. Now for the surprising bit. This whole loch was made by people less than two hundred years ago. The ground here used to be a soggy, muddy bog, and a man named Prince Albert, who was married to Queen Victoria, had the idea to turn the whole park into something beautiful. So workers dammed up the water and made this pretty loch where the swans now live. Every swan out there is swimming on a lake that somebody imagined and built.

It's named after a real queen, Saint Margaret, who lived about a thousand years ago and was so kind and so holy that people later called her a saint. There's a story that a tiny chapel to her once stood right by the water.

Higher up the hill, if your walk takes you that way, there's a second little loch called Dunsapie, tucked up near the top with a smashing view. That one was made by people too, part of the very same plan. And then, right down at the bottom on the far side, you'll find the third one, Duddingston Loch, and this one is the wild one, the real natural lake that was here all along. It's so full of birds that it's been turned into a special bird sanctuary, a safe place where the birds are protected and people aren't allowed to disturb them. It has the biggest bed of tall reeds for miles, a whispery green jungle where all sorts of birds hide and nest.

So you've got three lochs, two of them built by people to make the park pretty, and one truly wild one packed with birds. As you walk, see how many you can spot, and count the swans while you're at it. Just remember the golden rule of swans. Admire them all you like, but let them be the bosses.

The Mystery of the Seventeen Tiny Coffins

Here's a real unsolved mystery from this exact hill. One day in 1836, five boys were hunting rabbits on Arthur's Seat when they found a small cave hidden behind slabs of rock. Inside, arranged carefully in rows, were seventeen miniature coffins, each about the size of your hand. And inside each tiny coffin was a little carved wooden figure, with a painted face and hand-stitched clothes, tucked in like it was sleeping. Nobody knew who made them, who hid them, or why. Newspapers went wild. Was it witchcraft, a sailor's charm to protect friends lost at sea, or a child's secret game? The creepiest theory points to a crime: just eight years earlier, the killers Burke and Hare had murdered sixteen people in Edinburgh and sold the bodies. Sixteen victims, plus their first body, a man who died naturally, makes seventeen. Was someone giving each victim a secret, tiny funeral, since their real bodies never got one? We will never know for sure. The boys, being boys, reportedly threw a few at each other, but eight coffins survived, and you can see them in the National Museum of Scotland, for free, if the weather turns today. Look around as you walk. If a cave could hide here for years in a busy city park... what else might still be hidden?

The Little Coffins Up Close

Let's get a proper look at these strange little coffins, because the closer you look, the stranger and more wonderful they get. Whoever made them wasn't scribbling something silly in five minutes. They were careful, patient, and really quite skilled.

Each coffin is tiny, only about ninety-five millimetres long, which is roughly the length of your finger. Each one was made from a single little block of wood, hollowed out and shaped, with a lid that lifted off just like a real coffin. And they weren't left plain. The maker decorated the outsides with small pieces of tin, pressed into neat diamond shapes and dotted along the wood, as if these little boxes deserved to look proper and finished, not thrown together.

Now open one in your imagination and meet the figure inside. Each coffin held a small wooden person, carved with a face, with little arms, lying on its back as though peacefully asleep. And detectives spotted a clever, spooky detail much later. The figures weren't carved from scratch to be dead people. They seem to have started life as toy soldiers. Someone took ordinary little wooden soldiers, the kind a child might play with, and quietly changed them. In some cases the arms were trimmed away so the figures would fit neatly inside their boxes. Then each one was dressed in real clothes, tiny outfits stitched and glued around the wooden bodies, and tucked in.

Think about what that means. Somebody sat somewhere, probably by candlelight, turning cheerful toy soldiers into a row of little corpses in a row of little coffins. Not one. Seventeen. That's a lot of quiet, careful, secret work.

The people who studied the coffins even tried to guess what kind of person made them, just from the tool marks left in the wood. The cuts suggest someone used to working with sharp metal tools, maybe a shoemaker or a tinsmith, someone whose hands were good at small, exact jobs. So probably not a bored child, but a grown-up who knew what they were doing.

And remember where they were hidden. Not dropped on the ground, but tucked into a small cave on the hillside, sealed behind three pointed slabs of slate stood up like a little doorway. Someone wanted them hidden, but they also arranged them neatly inside, in careful rows, almost respectfully, as if this hidden cave were a secret little graveyard.

So we have skill, we have patience, we have seventeen of them, and we have a hiding place chosen on purpose. Every single one of those details is a clue. The trouble is, nobody left a note to say what the

clues add up to. That's the puzzle, and coming up, we'll put on our detective hats and weigh the best guesses.

Detective Time: Who and Why?

So who made the seventeen tiny coffins, and why on earth did they hide them on this hill? Time to think like a detective. We have clues but no confession, so everything that follows is a guess. Nobody has ever proved any of it. That's important, so hold onto it: these are theories, not answers.

First idea: witchcraft. Long ago, some people believed you could work magic on someone by making a little model of them. Cast a spell on the doll, and something bad would happen to the real person. Maybe the coffins were seventeen little curses. But detectives point out a problem. If you were cursing someone, you'd usually stab or burn or smash the little figure. You wouldn't gently dress it in stitched clothes and lay it lovingly in a decorated coffin. These figures were treated with care, almost kindness. So the witchcraft idea has a hole in it.

Second idea: sailors. In those days the sea was dangerous, and sailors drowned far from home all the time, with no body to bury and no grave to visit. There was a custom of making a small token, a stand-in, for a friend lost at sea, so he could be remembered properly. Could the coffins be seventeen lost sailors, each given a tiny burial by someone who loved them? It's possible. But nobody has found a shipwreck or a crew that matches, so it stays a maybe.

Now the idea most experts like best, and it's a chilling one. Cast your mind back to Burke and Hare, the two men who murdered people in Edinburgh and sold the bodies to be cut up for anatomy lessons. Their victims never got proper funerals, because their bodies were destroyed. And this is the part that makes detectives sit up: the numbers fit almost exactly. Burke and Hare were connected to seventeen dead people, sixteen they murdered and one who had died naturally. Seventeen victims with no graves. Seventeen tiny coffins on the hill. Maybe someone who knew what had happened made each victim a secret, hand-sized funeral, since the real world had given them none.

It's a haunting thought, and the counting really does line up. But even this favourite theory has never been proved. There's no letter, no diary, no witness. It's the best guess, not a fact.

So which is it? Curses, drowned sailors, or secret funerals for murdered strangers? A detective who's honest has to shrug and say, we don't know. And weirdly, that's the best part. Nearly two hundred years of clever people have studied these little boxes, and the mystery has beaten every one of them. Some puzzles just stay open, and this is one of the very best.

The Ones That Survived

Here's something amazing to think about. When those boys found the seventeen coffins in 1836, all seventeen were there, lined up in the cave. But today, only eight are left in the whole world. So what happened to the other nine? The answer is a little bit funny and a little bit sad: boys happened.

The story goes that the lads who found them didn't understand they'd stumbled on a great mystery. To them it was just a pile of odd little boxes, so, being boys, they reportedly started chucking them at each other. Some got smashed, some got lost in the grass, and the survivors were knocked about. That's why several of the ones you can see today look battered, with their clothes torn or missing. Imagine if they'd known that grown-up scientists would still be puzzling over these things nearly two hundred years later. They might have been a bit more careful.

The eight that made it had quite a journey. They passed from person to person, were shown off as a curiosity, and at one point were even sold at an auction. Finally, in the year nineteen hundred and one, a woman named Christina Couper gave her eight little coffins to the National Museum of Scotland, and

that's where they've stayed ever since. If the weather turns grey and drizzly today, that museum is the perfect place to go, it's warm, it's dry, and best of all it's free.

When you stand in front of that glass case, remember this. Scientists have done everything they can think of to these coffins. They've measured them, studied the wood, examined the tool marks, even looked at them with special machines to peek inside without opening them. And after all of that, all their cleverness and technology, they still cannot tell you who made them or why. The little coffins have kept their secret through everything.

Almost two hundred years. That's how long this puzzle has held out. People who lived and grew old and died never found out the answer, and passed the mystery on to the next lot, who passed it to us, who'll pass it to you.

So here's my challenge as you look at those eight survivors. Picture the hand that carved them, the fingers that stitched those tiny clothes, the person who climbed this very hill with a bundle under their coat and hid their little cargo behind three slabs of slate. Who were they, and what were they thinking? You get to wonder, just like everyone before you. And think on this too: if a whole cave full of coffins could stay hidden on a busy city hillside, waiting years to be found, then somewhere out there, other secrets must still be waiting. Maybe one of them is on this hill, right under your feet.

The Pub with a Sheep's Head Name

Down at the bottom of the hill, on the far side near Duddingston Loch, there's a little old village and in it sits a pub with one of the best names in Scotland. It's called the Sheep Heid Inn, and heid is the old Scottish word for head, so its name really means the Sheep's Head Inn. Now, why on earth would you name a place after a sheep's head?

Because hundreds of years ago, sheep were kept right here on the slopes of Arthur's Seat, the very hill you're climbing. When it was time, they were brought down to this village before being sent off to be sold in the city, and what happened to them in between is the sort of thing grown-ups find funny. So the village was famous for sheep, and the inn ended up wearing the name.

And this inn is old. Really, properly old. People say there has been a place to eat and drink on this exact spot since the year thirteen hundred and sixty. Stop and think about that number. That's more than six hundred and fifty years ago. That's older than almost anything you have ever stood inside. Knights in armour were still riding around when the first version of this inn opened its door. If the story is true, it may be the oldest pub in the whole of Scotland.

Even kings and queens have popped in. There's a tale that Mary, Queen of Scots, stopped here, and that her son, who grew up to be King James, loved the place. The story goes that one day in the fifteen hundreds, King James had such a brilliant time here that he gave the owners a very strange thank-you present. A snuff box. And what was the snuff box shaped like? A ram's head, of course, with real curly horns, to match the name of the inn. A king gave them a fancy little box shaped like a sheep's head. You couldn't make it up.

So as you look down toward that village, remember that tucked in there is a little inn that has been serving people since knights were real, that a king once handed a silly horned present to, and that got its name from the woolly sheep who once wandered the very hill under your feet. And there's one more thing hiding in that ancient pub, a game so old it will make your eyes pop, and that's coming next.

The Oldest Game of Skittles

Inside that ancient sheep's head inn there is something wonderful, and it's a game. It's called skittles, and it might just be the oldest one of its kind still being played anywhere in Scotland. If you've ever been ten-pin bowling, you already know how it works, because skittles is bowling's great-great-great-grandparent.

The game works like this. At the far end of a long narrow lane, someone stands up nine wooden pins, called skittles, in a neat little pattern. Then, from the other end, you roll a heavy ball, or sometimes throw a wooden disc, straight down the lane and try to knock over as many pins as you can. Knock them all down and everyone cheers. Miss, and the ball rolls sadly off to the side while everyone groans. It's simple, it's noisy, and people have been playing it for a very, very long time.

Now the amazing part. Kings and queens didn't just visit this inn to eat. They played this exact game in the yard behind it, hundreds of years ago. There's a story that King James, the same one who gave the sheep's head snuff box, rolled a few balls down the lane himself and had such fun that he handed over that present. So when children play skittles there today, they're playing the same game a king once played, on the same old spot, all those centuries ago.

The skittle lane they use now is well over a hundred years old, and the wooden pins they knock down are antiques, older than your great-grandparents. Imagine that. In most games you'd be careful with

something that old and put it behind glass in a museum. Here, they still bowl balls straight at it for fun, the way people always have.

Think about how many hands have rolled a ball down that lane. Farmers, sailors, grannies, soldiers, kings, and children just like you, all the way back through the years, all trying to knock down the same kind of little wooden pins and all doing a happy little dance when they managed it. Some games come and go, but this one has stuck around for hundreds of years, because knocking things down with a ball is just brilliant, and it always will be.

So next time you go bowling, do a tiny bit of showing off and tell everyone you know where the game came from. An ancient inn in Scotland, at the foot of a volcano, named after a sheep.

The Loch Where a Sport Was Born

Remember that wild loch at the bottom of the hill, Duddingston Loch, the one packed with birds? Well, in winter, something magical used to happen to it, and it may just be the birthplace of a whole sport.

Long ago, Scotland had proper freezing winters, so cold that this loch would freeze right over into a sheet of thick, solid ice. And when that happened, the whole city seemed to rush down to play on it. People strapped blades to their boots and went skating, whizzing and gliding across the frozen water. But they also invented something cleverer, a game called curling, and lots of people think curling was born right here on this very loch.

Curling is a brilliant, slightly bonkers game. You slide a big heavy polished stone across the ice, trying to make it stop in exactly the right spot, while your teammates run alongside it frantically sweeping the ice with brooms to help it slide further. Yes, really, sweeping the ice with brooms, in the middle of a game, like the tidiest sport ever invented. It looks a bit silly and it is enormously good fun, and Scotland is so proud of it that people now play curling at the Winter Olympics. And it may all have started on this little loch below Arthur's Seat. There was even a special wee building on the shore, a Curling House, just for the players and their heavy stones.

There's a famous painting of this frozen loch too, and it's one of the best-loved pictures in all of Scotland. It shows a man in a smart black coat and a tall black hat, gliding across the ice on one leg, arms folded, looking extremely pleased with himself. He was a real person, a minister, which is a kind of church leader, and everyone calls the painting the Skating Minister. There he is, calm as anything, skating on this exact loch more than two hundred years ago. You can go and see the real painting in a gallery in the city, and once you've seen it you never forget it.

So picture it. A freezing winter's day, the loch turned to glass, the whole city out on the ice, skaters gliding, stones sliding, brooms sweeping, and one very dignified minister balanced on a single skate. All of it, right here, at the foot of your volcano. And coming up next, there's a sneaky old train that used to creep right underneath this park, and you'd never even know it was there.

The Sneaky Innocent Railway

Now here's a secret hiding right at the edge of this park. There is a tunnel, a long dark tunnel, running underneath the ground near Arthur's Seat, and nearly two hundred years ago trains used to rumble through it. And the whole thing had the funniest, gentlest name. People called it the Innocent Railway.

Innocent? Why would a train be called innocent, like it hadn't done anything naughty? The answer is my favourite part. When railways were brand new, the very first steam trains scared people half to death. They were huge, they hissed and roared, they belched smoke, and they went terrifyingly fast, so fast that folk genuinely worried you might not be able to breathe. But this little railway didn't use a scary steam engine to pull its wagons along. It used horses. Actual horses, clip-clopping along, tugging the wagons on the rails. Because it was pulled by calm, friendly horses instead of a snorting steam monster, people decided it was safe and gentle and, well, innocent. And the name stuck.

The railway opened in the year eighteen thirty-one, which makes it one of the very first railways in all of Scotland, and its tunnel was the first railway tunnel the country ever had. It was built to carry coal into the city to keep everyone's fires burning, but then a clever man had an idea. He stuck a coach on the rails and started giving people rides, and it was such a hit that fourteen thousand passengers piled on in the very first month. Fourteen thousand. Everybody wanted a go on the gentle horse-train.

To get the wagons through that long tunnel under the park, they used a huge rope and a machine that hauled them along, because horses don't much like dark tunnels. Imagine being a wagon full of coal, creaking through the black tunnel on the end of a giant rope, with the whole hill sitting on top of you.

The trains are long gone now, but the tunnel is still there, and so is the old railway track, and today people walk and cycle right through it. You can stroll along the very path where the horses once pulled their wagons, and step into that same tunnel the coal trains rumbled through, with Arthur's Seat rising up above your head. A sneaky old horse-railway, hidden under a volcano, with the friendliest name a train ever had.